Learn the Signs. Act Early.

# Milestones by 4 Months

TABLE OF CONTENTS | PAGE 2 OF 13 | ALL PAGES ↓

For Everyone

MAY 15, 2026 • ESPAÑOL

**WHAT TO KNOW**

- Learn about the developmental milestones that most babies do by four months of age.
- See important information to share with your doctor.
- Find tips and activities you can do for your four-month-old.



## Ways to monitor milestones

How your child plays, learns, speaks, acts, and moves offers important clues about your child's development. Developmental miles things most children (75% or more) can do by a certain age.

### Milestone checklists

Check the milestones your baby has reached by 4 months by completing a checklist, available below and in three additional forma

- CDC's free *Milestone Tracker* mobile app, for iOS and Android devices
- Web-based Digital Online Checklist
- Printable checklist PDF

**Keep in mind**

*Learn the Signs. Act Early.* materials are not a substitute for standardized, validated developmental screening tools.

## What most babies do by 4 months

**Click the links below to view a photo or video of each milestone.**

### Social/Emotional Milestones

- Smiles on his own to get your attention
- Chuckles (not yet a full laugh) when you try to make him laugh
- Looks at you, moves, or makes sounds to get or keep your attention

### Language/Communication Milestones

- Makes sounds like “oooo”, “aahh” (cooing)
- Makes sounds back when you talk to him
- Turns head towards the sound of your voice

### Cognitive Milestones (learning, thinking, problem-solving)

- If hungry, opens mouth when he sees breast or bottle
- Looks at her hands with interest

### Movement/Physical Development Milestones

- Holds head steady without support when you are holding him
- Holds a toy when you put it in his hand
- Uses his arm to swing at toys
- Brings hands to mouth
- Pushes up onto elbows/forearms when on tummy

SEE ALSO
More about physical development

## Share with your child’s doctor

### Things to share and consider

- What are some things you and your baby do together?
- What are some things your baby likes to do?
- Is there anything your baby does or does not do that concerns you?
- Has your baby lost any skills he/she once had?
- Does your baby have any special healthcare needs or was he/she born prematurely?

**You know your child best.** Don't wait. If your child is not meeting one or more milestones, has lost skills he or she once had, or you concerns, act early. Talk with your child's doctor, share your concerns, and ask about developmental screening.

**If you or the doctor are still concerned**

- Ask for a referral to a specialist who can evaluate your child more; and
- Call your state or territory's early intervention program to find out if your child can get services to help. Learn more and find t at cdc.gov/FindEI.

KEEP READING
Concerned About Your Child's Development?

# Tips and activities

## What you can do for your 4-month-old



As your baby's first teacher, you can help his or her development.

As your baby's first teacher, you can help his or her learning and brain development. Try these simple tips and activities in a safe w your baby's doctor and teachers if you have questions or for more ideas on how to help your baby's development.

- Respond positively to your baby. Act excited, smile, and talk to him when he makes sounds. This teaches him to take turns "talki forth in conversation.
- Provide safe opportunities for your baby to reach for toys, kick at toys and explore what is around her. For example, put her on a safe toys.
- Allow your baby to put safe things in his mouth to explore them. This is how babies learn. For example, let him see, hear, and to

are not sharp, hot, or small enough to choke on.

### More Parenting Tips and Activities

- Talk, read, and sing to your baby. This will help her learn to speak and understand words later.
- Limit screen time (TV, phones, tablets, etc.) to video calling with loved ones. Screen time is not recommended for children yo 2 years of age. Babies learn by talking, playing, and interacting with others.
- Feed only breast milk or formula to your baby. Babies are not ready for other foods, water or other drinks for about the first 6 life.
- Give your baby safe toys to play with that are easy to hold, like rattles or cloth books with colorful pictures for her age.
- Let your baby have time to move and interact with people and objects throughout the day. Try not to keep your baby in swin or bouncy seats for too long.
- Set steady routines for sleeping and feeding.
- Lay your baby on her back and show her a bright-colored toy. Move the toy slowly from left to right and up and down to see watches how the toy moves.
- Sing and talk to your baby as you help her "exercise" (move her body) for a few minutes. Gently bend and move her arms an and down.
- Play with your baby by holding him securely under his arms with his feet on your lap. Let him bounce up and down.
- Play games, such as peek-a-boo. You can cover your eyes with your hands and then uncover and say "peek-a-boo." Watch fo baby's smile or other signs he is enjoying the game.
- Pay close attention to how your baby reacts to different things. This will help you learn what she likes and doesn't like and w her feel good.
- Copy your baby's sounds and see how long your baby "talks" back and forth with you.
- Call your baby by his name to help him learn it. He will start to recognize it around 9 months. For example, "Are you ticklish,
- Playing on the floor or play mat with your baby every day helps him to move, learn, and explore.
- Hold and talk to your baby; smile and be cheerful while you do.
- Have quiet play times when you "read" or sing to your baby.

TABLE OF CONTENTS | TABLE OF CONTENTS

- Milestones by 2 Months
- **Milestones by 4 Months**
- Milestones by 6 Months

SHOW MORE

SOURCES AND PAGE INFO

CONTENT SOURCE
National Center on Birth Defects and Developmental Disabilities (NCBDDD)

ABOUT THIS PAGE

**Published:** September 4, 2025

**Updated:** May 16, 2026

This page was last updated on this date. Updates may include minor edits, image changes, or other modifications to page content.

**Reviewed:** May 16, 2026

The information on this page was last reviewed by subject matter experts to ensure accuracy.

SOURCES

- *Special acknowledgments to the subject matter experts and others who contributed to the review of data and selection of deve milestones, especially Paul H. Lipkin, MD, Michelle M. Macias, MD, Julie F. Pajek, PhD, Judith S. Shaw, EdD, MPH, RN, Karnesha MPH, Jane K. Squires, PhD, Toni M. Whitaker, MD, Lisa D. Wiggins, PhD, and Jennifer M. Zubler, MD.*
- *Sincere gratitude to Natalia Benza, MD and José O. Rodríguez, MD, MBA for their thoughtful review of the Spanish-language tr these milestones.*